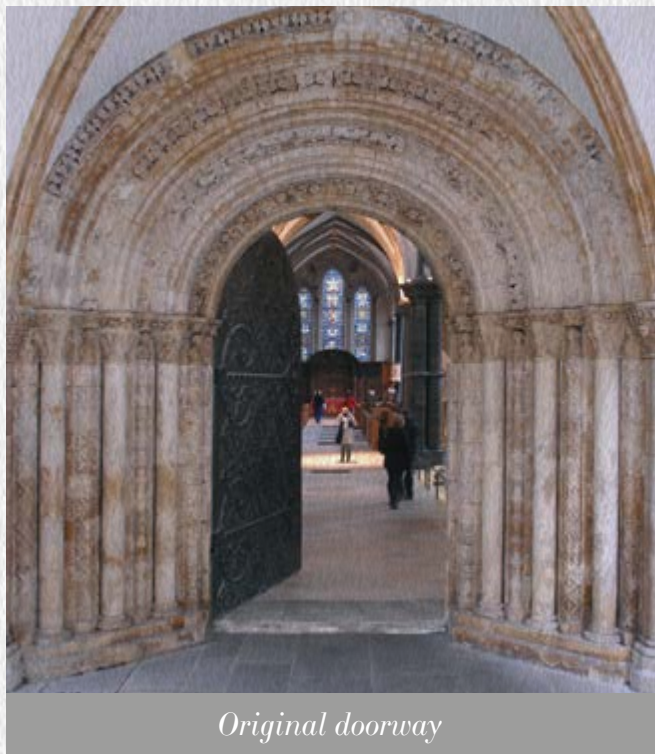


The Temple Church

No. 151

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

April 2026



Original doorway



William Marshal, Earl of Pembroke

The Temple Church is among the oldest and most beautiful churches in London.

It was built by the Knights Templar, an order of crusading monks founded in 1118 to protect pilgrims to the Holy Land. The Templars became one of the most powerful orders in Christendom. The Temple was their headquarters in England, with the Church, two Halls, cloisters and domestic buildings leading to the River Thames.

The Round Church was consecrated in 1185. It was modelled on the Church of the Holy Sepulchre in Jerusalem. To be in the Round was to be reminded of Christ's burial, our baptism into his death, and resurrection to new life.

The effigies include William Marshal, Earl of Pembroke (d.1219), chief adviser to King John and regent during the minority of Henry III. His son William and Brother Aymeric, Master of the Knights Templar in England, witnessed the sealing of Magna Carta in 1215. Earlier that year, barons met King John at the Temple to demand the confirmation of ancient laws and liberties.

The Chancel was built in 1240. Henry III planned to be buried here, perhaps explaining its unusual design.

The Templars were suppressed between 1307 and 1311. By the 15th century, the lawyers of Inner and Middle Temple were established here.

During the Reformation, the Temple Church was the scene of the "battle of the pulpits" between Richard Hooker and Walter Travers. Their debate inspired Hooker's *The Laws of Ecclesiastical Polity*, a foundation of Anglican theology.

In 1608, King James I granted the Temple to the two Inns of Court on condition they maintain the church and its services. Queen Elizabeth II visited in 2008 when new Letters Patent were granted.

Sir Christopher Wren refurbished the Church in the 1670s. Apart from the magnificent reredos, his work was removed during Victorian restoration in the 1840s.

The Church suffered extensive wartime damage in 1941 and was restored 17 years later using dark Purbeck marble.

Today, the Church has a renowned choir, supports regular worship, hosts concerts and lectures, and remains a place of peace in the heart of the City.

The Church has a particularly fine choir which supports regular worship according to the Book of Common Prayer. The Church also hosts concerts, lectures and discussions on matters of current socio-legal interest, as well as being a haven of tranquillity and calm in the midst of the busy City.